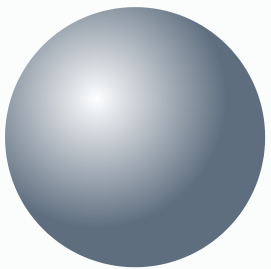
How our idea of the atom has changed

1803

Dalton

"billiard ball"

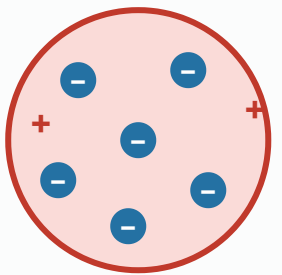


Atoms are tiny solid spheres that cannot be divided.

1904

Thomson

"plum pudding"

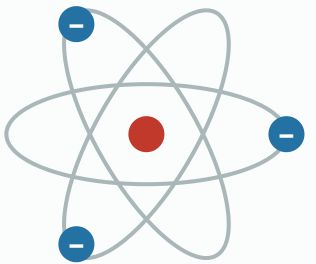


A positive sphere with negative electrons stuck in it.

1911

Rutherford

"planetary"

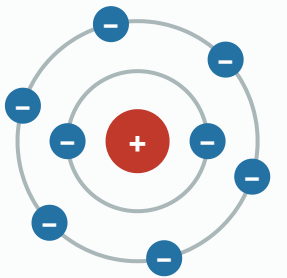


A tiny, dense positive nucleus; electrons move around it. The atom is mostly empty!

1913

Bohr

"energy levels"



Electrons move in fixed shells (energy levels) around the nucleus.